

The Islamic Republic of Iran is currently host to one of the largest and most protracted refugee populations in the world, the majority of whom are Afghan refugees. In protecting refugees and asylum seekers in Iran, since 1984 UNHCR has worked closely with the Government of the Islamic Republic of Iran, national and international NGO's and UN agencies providing a multitude of services. UNHCR provides protection support through the provision of legal assistance, communicating with communities including through helplines and receptions centres, cash-based interventions, psycho-social support, gender-based violence related prevention and response services, child protection services, facilitation of voluntary repatriation and durable solutions. Since 2002, UNHCR Iran has supported nearly 1 million refugees to voluntary repatriate in safety and dignity to Afghanistan and Iraq. The situation in Iran was exacerbated following the events of August 2021 in Afghanistan, which led to UNHCR issuing a non-returns advisory in its Global Guidance Note on the International Protection Needs of People Fleeing Afghanistan, issued in February 2022. Through the Solutions Strategy for Afghan Refugees (SSAR), UNHCR also works with the Government to support inclusive refugee policies and services, in particular in health and education.

POPULATION BY DOCUMENTATION STATUS

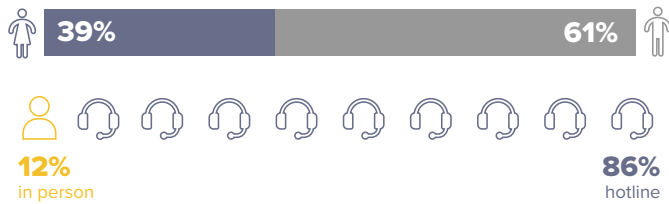
In view of widespread instability in Afghanistan, as part of its protection mandate, UNHCR continues to advocate for an open and accessible asylum system for all. Many among the undocumented population are likely to have international protection needs, particularly as the situation continues to deteriorate in Afghanistan, for which they need to be properly screened and identified. Meanwhile, UNHCR continues to advocate for the extension of temporary protection and documentation to Afghans indicating an unwillingness and inability to return, in particular those most at risk. The initiative of the Government of the Islamic Republic of Iran to conduct a headcount and issue (short term) documentation to 2.6 million Afghans is a major step in this regard, UNHCR continues to advocate for enabling those who did not participate as well as new arrivals to utilize the process and regularize their status. UNHCR continues to advocate on behalf of those who did not participate as well as new arrivals in Iran after the conclusion of the headcount exercise, with the purpose of regularizing their status in Iran.



Figures reported are based on BAFIA provided information in December 2022.

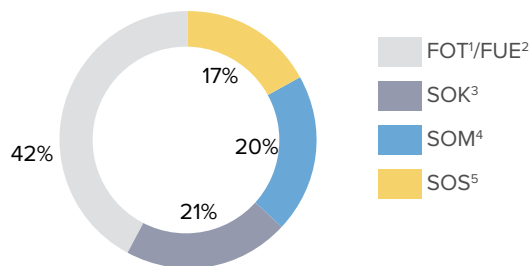
RECEPTION

By the end of 2022, **36,729** individuals contacted UNHCR more than one time, out of which 15,421 were newly recorded in proGres. The large majority of them were asylum-seekers (Asylum-seekers 75%, Amayesh card holders 24% and other of concern 1%).



2% of the refugees and asylum seekers used other means of approach to UNHCR.

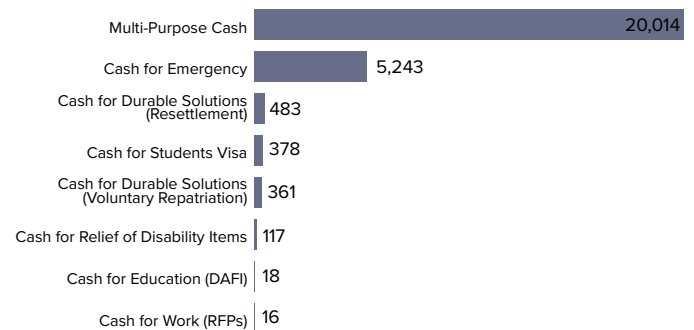
APPROACHES BY OFFICES



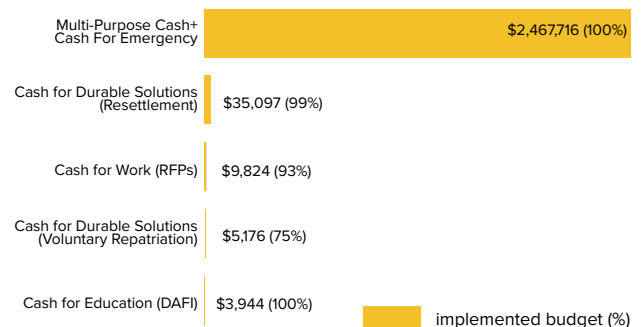
CASH BASED INTERVENTIONS

26,224 unique individuals related to 6,722 households in total received cash assistance by the end of 2022 from UNHCR. Due to different vulnerabilities, some households received cash assistance more than one time (see chart below).

ASSISTED POPULATION BY ASSISTANCE TYPE



BUDGET BY ASSISTANCE TYPE



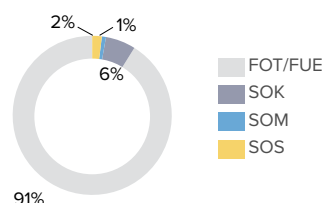
COMMUNITY-BASED PROTECTION (CBP)

AWARENESS RAISING AND INFORMATION DISSEMINATION

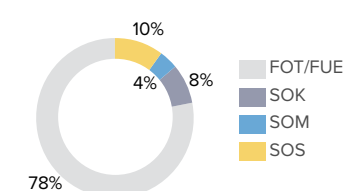
Participatory community engagement is key to improving the impact, legitimacy, and transparency of program planning and implementation; this is one of the core values of Community Based Protection (CBP). CBP seeks to ensure that refugee girls, boys, women and men are empowered, and their capacities and resilience are strengthened, enabling them to minimize exposure to protection risks and thus improve the overall protection environment. CBP activities aim to enhance access to services, including by identifying and addressing barriers building on meaningful participation of diverse individuals and groups, particularly of women and youth. In total in 2022, 54,548 individuals were reached in person and 3,057 individuals were approached virtually - these individuals were provided with information on rights and obligations while also giving feedback to UNHCR. Information was disseminated on UNHCR services, the headcount exercise, resettlement, hygiene awareness, parenting issues, and communication skills. Celebrations of World Refugee Day were an important mobilization moment for communities. To reach communities across the country the CBP team conducted various missions, which included 10 participatory assessments, 150 Focus Group Discussions, and 575 awareness-raising and information dissemination activities on the above-mentioned topics.

In order to streamline the UNHCR feedback and response mechanism, an updated standard operating procedure for the hotline was tested in a pilot in Tehran for a 30 day period in November and December 2022, with the analysis of findings aiming to yield countrywide improvements. Dedicated phone operators were assigned to maximize UNHCR interaction with refugees and asylum seekers. Furthermore, with the lifting of COVID-19 restrictions, offices are enhancing capacities to maximize face-to-face outreach, which will further strengthen information exchange on thematic protection areas and ensuring accessibility of UNHCR to refugees and asylum seekers.

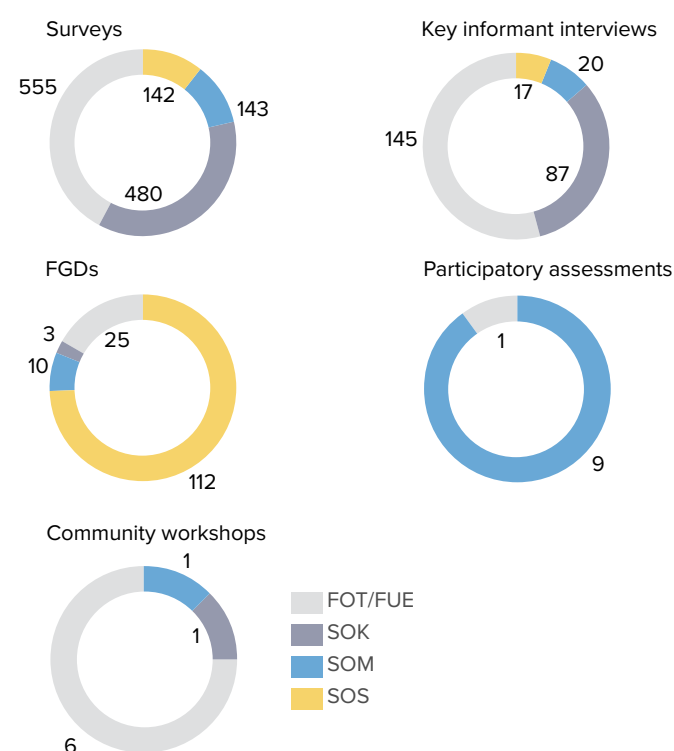
REFUGEES & ASYLUM SEEKERS ENGAGED BY OFFICES



NUMBER OF ACTIVITIES BY OFFICES



NUMBER OF PARTICIPATORY DATA COLLECTION EXERCISES CONDUCTED



PSYCHO-SOCIAL SUPPORT

Displacement has a profound impact on people and their communities. People who flee their homes are particularly vulnerable to emotional stress. It is estimated that one in five people in conflict-affected settings suffers from depression, post-traumatic stress disorder, complicated grief, or other mental health conditions. To address the mental health needs of refugees approaching us, UNHCR Iran has contracted one Psycho-Social Counsellor (PSC) per office, to provide part-time individual counseling to individuals in need. Priority is given to survivors of GBV, but also survivors of torture and trauma, cases of attempted suicide, survivors and perpetrators of child abuse, substance users, and others at risk. In consultation with UNHCR, and with the consent of involved individuals, the PSCs may make referrals to the other specialists and/or the national system, if needed. In November, UNHCR organized a two-days in-person workshop for the PSCs from across the country. PSCs were provided with general information related to UNHCR's mandate and scope including how this is operationalized as well as information on basic principles and measures related to anti-fraud and integrity. The PSCs were also trained on provision of MHPSS in Humanitarian Contexts, with a special focus on vulnerable groups as such LGBTIQ+ and counselling in the context of CP/GBV case management. The workshop adopted a participatory environment approach that facilitated peer learning and a free exchange of experiences and ideas, ultimately enhancing counselling activities.

2,344

individuals reached with psycho-social support counselling



GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE (GBV)

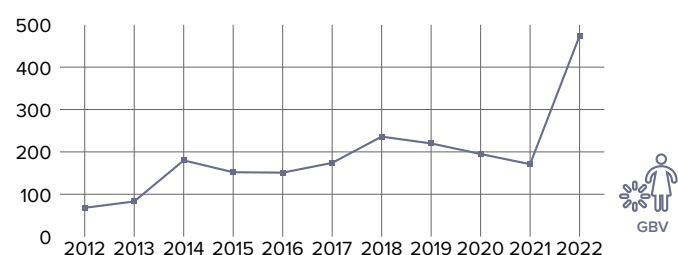
In 2022, UNHCR identified and supported 474 GBV survivors which shows an overall 77% rise in the number of GBV survivors identified compared to the previous year. This increase is understood to be a result of the recruitment of dedicated GBV staff who receive the cases and conduct in-depth interviews and address the needs but also amplified sensitization of all frontline staff by training. The most prevalent category of GBV incidents is physical assault (38%), confirming the trend in the previous quarters followed by psychological/emotional abuse (17%) and rape (14%). The overwhelming majority of the GBV survivors (95%) continue to be women and girls. During the 16 Days of Activism against Gender-based Violence campaign, UNHCR Iran initiated and organized several activities to increase awareness of Gender-Based Violence (GBV) and build the capacity of staff on prevention and response to GBV. In total 393 refugees, including community leaders and influential figures participated in activities despite sensitivities around the topic in the Iranian context. Moreover, the CP/GBV Unit designed a Client Feedback Survey which is being conducted for the first time in Iran operation. The survey, launched in December 2022, aims to understand the experience of the GBV survivors with UNHCR's services and what needs to get improved.

474

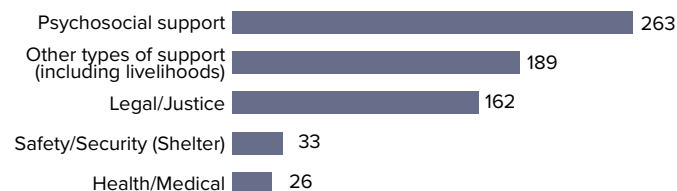
Reported GBV survivors



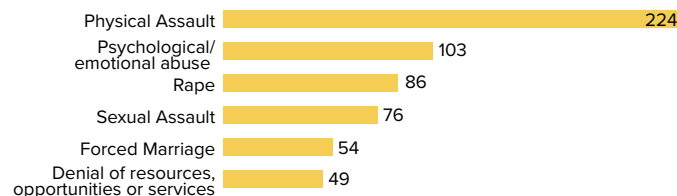
TREND: REPORTED GBV SURVIVORS OVER THE YEARS



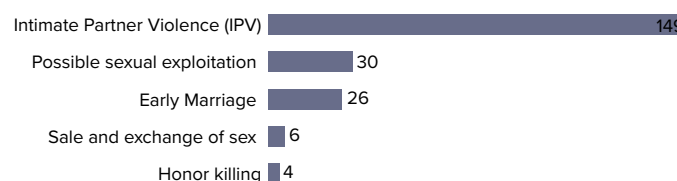
TYPES OF SERVICES PROVIDED



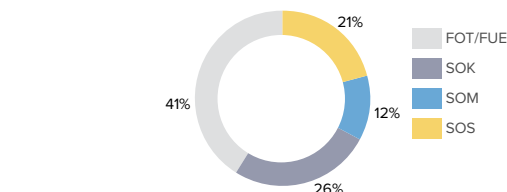
INCIDENT TYPES



GBV CASE CONTEXT



NUMBER OF GBV SURVIVORS IDENTIFIED BY OFFICES



CHILD PROTECTION (CP)

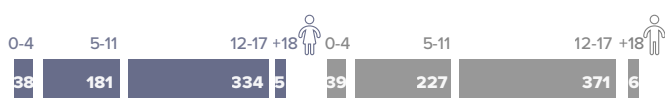
UNHCR field offices' reports and collected data prove that a significant number of child asylum seekers and refugees are facing risks in the areas of access of education, documentation and child labour, among others. While Iran's government issued several announcements on the enrollment of undocumented Afghan children, the scope of implementation has remained limited in some areas. It has been observed that some undocumented children did not manage to successfully complete the pre-registration processes due to lack of information or administrative challenges. Others were not enrolled due to lack of capacity in schools. UNHCR offices recorded 2480 child at risk of not attending school since the beginning of 2022, almost half of them (1018 cases) identified in Q4. The actual figure of those not able to enroll in education is likely much higher.

Since the amendment of Nationality Bill in favor of Children Born to Iranian mothers and non-Iranian fathers, more than 80,000 applications have been filed, the majority of them for children born to Iranian mothers and Afghan fathers. The Iranian authorities announced in September 2022, that 14,000 children have already obtained nationality. This is almost double the number announced in September 2021. Since then, no further data is shared in this regard. UNHCR is following legislative developments in relation to the Nationality Bill closely and advocates for maintenance of access to the scheme.

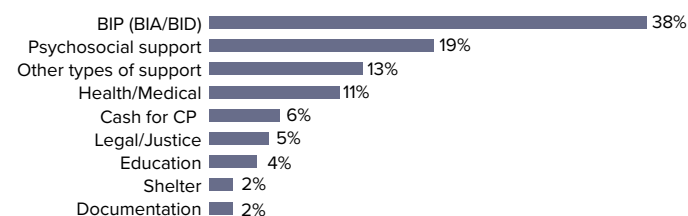
Although the number of the child laborers identified remained limited (391 throughout 2022), field reports confirm how widespread is the phenomenon is. Authorities at various levels have also raised concerns in this regard, especially in the face of more Afghan families arriving in Iran without much economic opportunities available to them in the country. UNHCR aims to work with partners and Government institutions to mitigate risks for children.

1,201

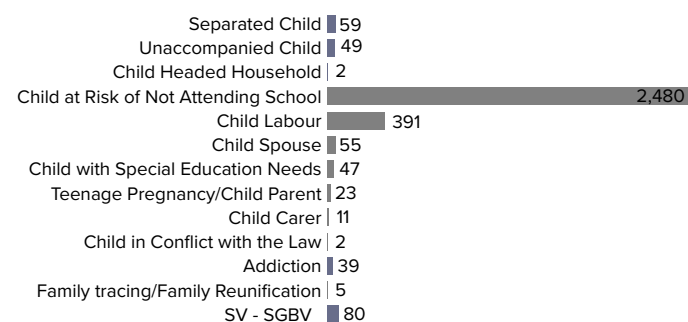
Reported children at risk



TYPES OF SERVICES PROVIDED/REFERRALS

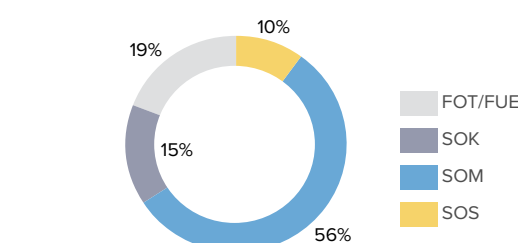


TYPES OF SPECIFIC NEEDS



In the chart above, one child may fall under several of these specific needs categories.

CHILDREN AT RISK IDENTIFIED BY OFFICE



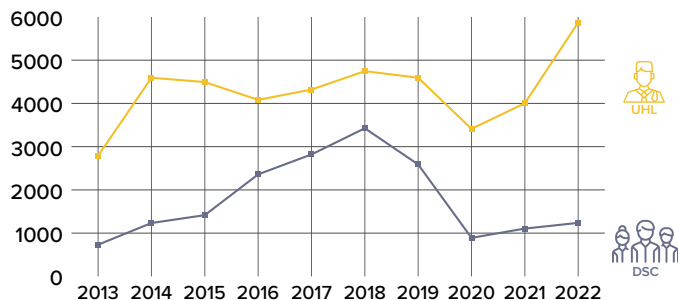
LEGAL SERVICES

By the end of 2022, the number of consultations provided by UNHCR Hired Lawyers (UHLs) represents 37% increase compared to 2021. The majority of the cases that UHLs supported, concerned "Family disputes", "Criminal matters" and "Civil and financial disputes". Dispute Settlement Committees (DSCs) approaches increased by 21% compared to 2021; this is due to a more limited number of active DSCs due to Covid-19 restrictions in 2021. "Family disputes", followed by "Financial disputes" and "Wage-related disputes" were the three most frequent areas that DSCs intervened in. Although refugees have access to Iranian courts, the DSCs offer an alternative and free-of-charge dispute resolution mechanism that complements judicial processes by finding amicable solutions in mostly civil matters involving refugees.

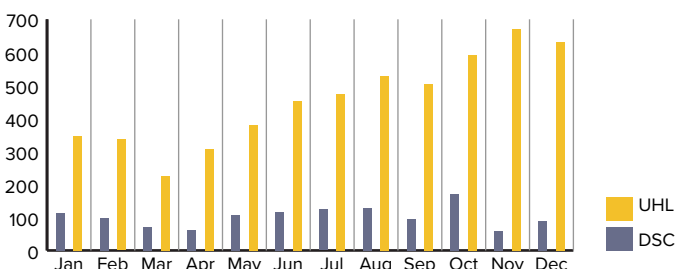
1,380 individuals supported through **16** Dispute Settlement Committees

5,905 individuals supported by **17** UNHCR Hired Lawyers

TREND: UHL & DSC BENEFICIARIES OVER THE YEARS



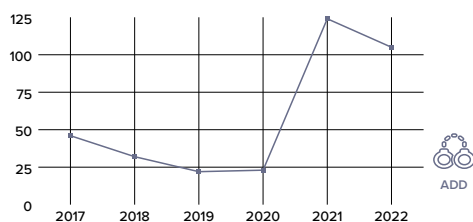
TREND: UHL & DSC INDIVIDUALS IN 2022



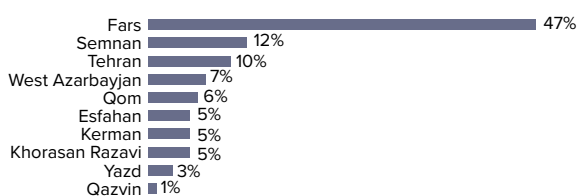
ARREST, DETENTION & DEPORTATION (ADD)

ADD incidents directly reported to UNHCR by affected refugees and asylum seekers (or relatives on their behalf) represent a minimal portion of the total number of ADD incidents taking place in Iran. During the reporting period, only 72 ADD incidents concerning 105 individuals were directly reported to UNHCR, largely on grounds of irregular border crossing and lack of valid documentation. Afghans without valid documentation are at risk of arrest, detention, and deportation in Iran. Amayesh Card holders must obtain a Laissez-Passer (travel permit) from authorities for traveling outside their designated province of residence. During 2022, undocumented Afghans and also those not carrying their documentation at the time of apprehension, continued to be the target of roundup operations by law enforcement authorities. Deportations often follow despite the non-return advisory issued by UNHCR contained within the February 2022 Guidance Note on International Protection Needs of People Fleeing Afghanistan. Key informants reported that detainees are not abruptly deported but undergo a screening process following which some are released and allowed to remain in the country. However, public statements of officials indicate large scale deportations, with figures reported for the year into the 100,000s. Key informants also reported an increase in the deportation trend as an increasing number of Afghans succeed to enter Iran via unofficial crossings. This increasing deportation trend is believed to be linked to perceptions around Afghans negatively impacting the economy and affecting the local populations' access to job opportunities. Furthermore, xenophobic messages circulated in media outlets seem to have exacerbated a pattern by which law enforcement authorities apply legal stay/residency regulations more strictly.

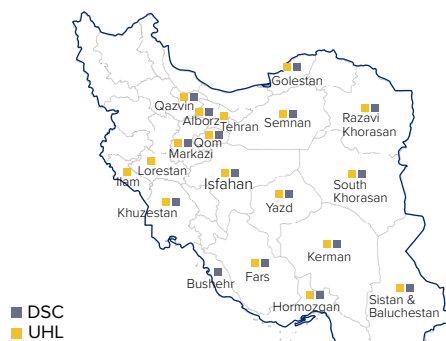
TREND: DIRECTLY REPORTED ADD CASES TO UNHCR OVER THE YEARS



PLACE OF ARREST OF DIRECTLY REPORTED CASES

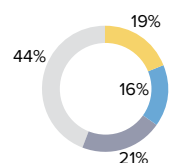


UHL & DSC LOCATIONS

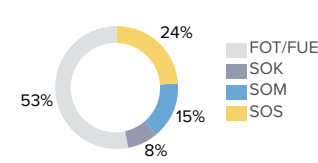


Note: The markers on the map indicate presence of UHL and/or DSC in provinces.

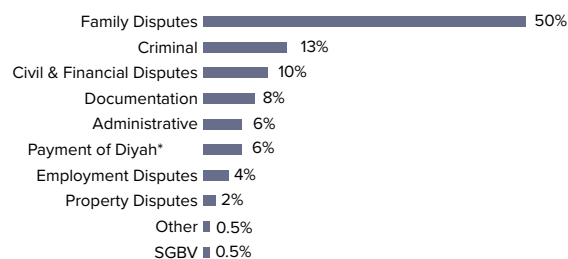
DSC BENEFICIARIES/OFFICES



UHL BENEFICIARIES/OFFICES



UHL TYPE OF CASES

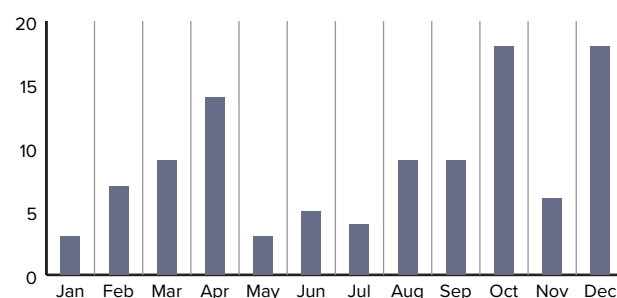


* Diah in Islamic law, is the financial compensation paid to the victim or heirs of a victim in the cases of murder, bodily harm or property damage by mistake.

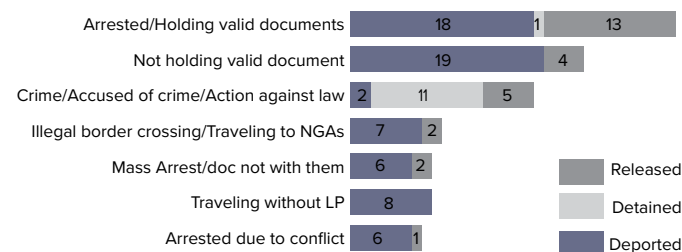
105

individuals

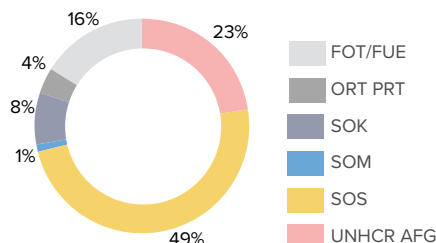
TREND: ADD CASES DIRECTLY REPORTED IN 2022



REASON OF ARREST OF DIRECTLY REPORTED CASES



ADD CASES PER OFFICES



VOLUNTARY REPATRIATION

In 2022, UNHCR facilitated the repatriation of 376 returnees to Afghanistan and 2 returnees to Iraq. This represents a substantial decrease compared to the 875 returns facilitated in 2021. This represents a 57% decrease in voluntary repatriation, compared to 2021 during which there were 875 returns. This decrease is due to the instability and deteriorating humanitarian situation in Afghanistan. UNHCR offers support to those opting to return aiming to ensure that such returns are informed, voluntary, safe, and dignified.

376

Afghan refugees voluntary repatriated
(including students)

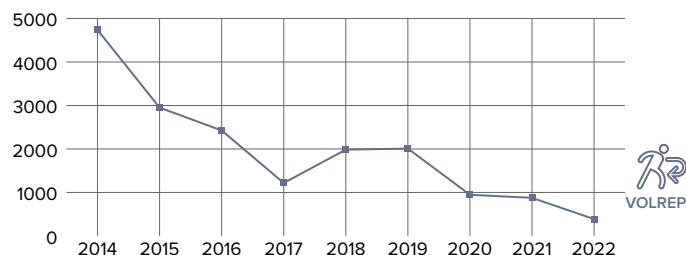
2

Iraqi refugee voluntary repatriated

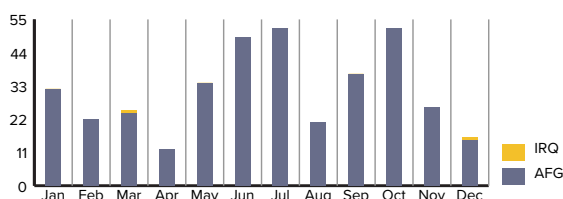
AGE AND GENDER DISAGGREGATION OF THOSE OPTING TO RETURN



TREND: VOLUNTARY REPATRIATION OVER THE YEARS



TREND: VOLUNTARY REPATRIATION IN 2022



RESETTLEMENT

UNHCR Iran has tentatively received 3,000 resettlement slots for 2022. From January to end December 2022, the office submitted 3,125 individuals for resettlement consideration to third countries. In the same reporting period, 153 individuals departed on resettlement.

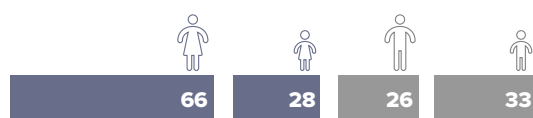
3,125

refugees submitted to resettlement
countries for consideration

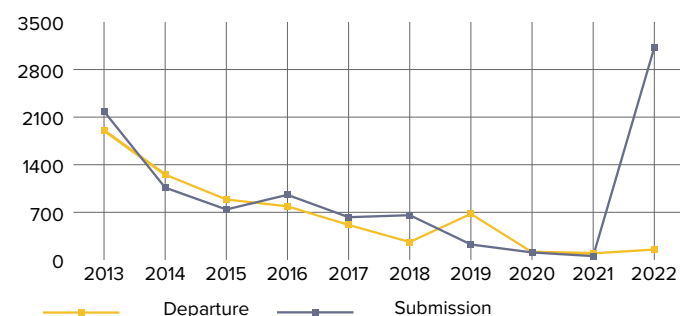
153

refugees departed to the resettlement
countries

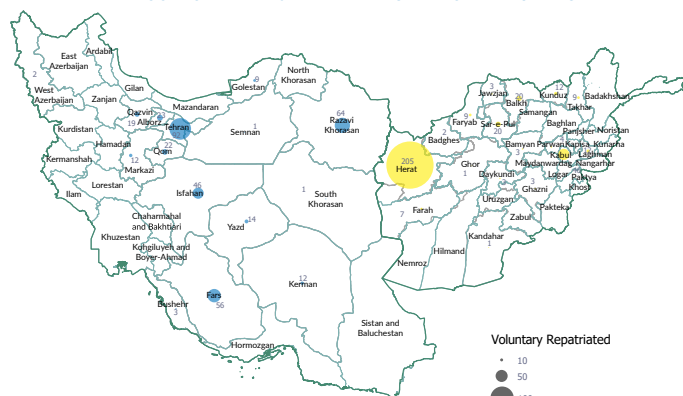
AGE AND GENDER DISAGGREGATION OF THOSE WHO DEPARTED FOR RESETTLEMENT



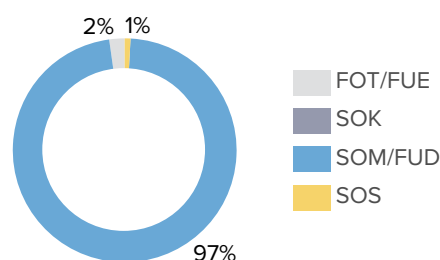
TREND: RESETTLEMENT OVER THE YEARS



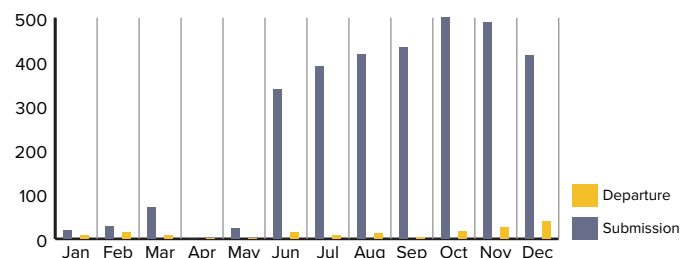
REPATRIATED BY LOCATION IN IRAN & INTENDED DESTINATION IN AFGHANISTAN



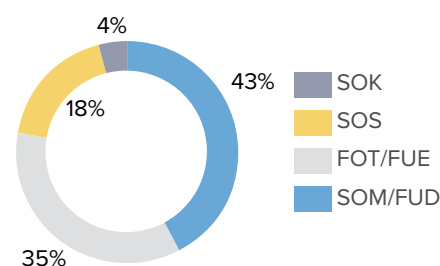
PROCESSED BY OFFICES



TREND: RESETTLEMENT IN 2022



DEPARTED INDIVIDUALS BY UNHCR OFFICES



PRIORITY OF SUBMISSION:

105 urgent/3,020 normal